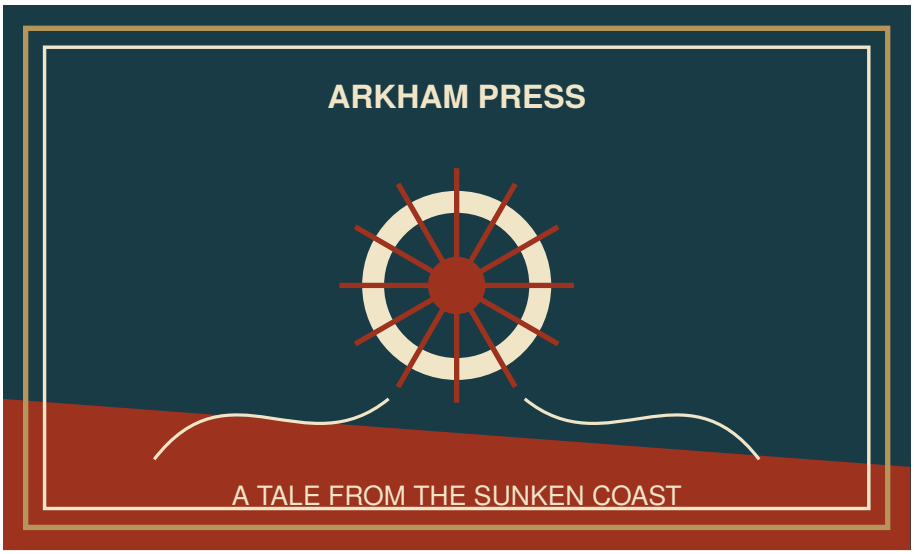
STRANGE TALES OF THE ABYSS

THE NECRONOMICON PROJECT

A Pulp Edition



The Tide That Remembered

A fantastic new tale by A. M. Vale

ARKHAM PRESS • 1928

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The Chart in the Bottle

When Mara Bell found the bottle, the tide was running inland. She stood on the black shingle below Greyhaven, where the stones clicked together like teeth in a cold mouth. The bottle rested above the foam, dry as a bone, and its cork bore a neat brass seal.

Inside lay a chart of the coast, drawn with a sailor's confidence and a surveyor's care. Greyhaven was marked, as were the reef, the lighthouse, and the old customs house. Beyond them, in water no chart admitted, someone had inked a second coastline. It curved around the harbor like an enormous closed hand.

Mara had inherited her father's map case and his habit of checking every measurement twice. She measured the distance from the customs house to the newly drawn shore. The scale gave nine miles. The actual distance was the width of the harbor.

Dr. Voss arrived carrying a lantern and a satchel of notebooks. He did not ask where she had found the bottle. He asked whether it had been warm. Mara answered that the glass was cold. The doctor looked disappointed, then afraid, as though the bottle had failed a test he had hoped it would pass.

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The Door Below the Stairs

The customs house smelled of wet paper and extinguished candles. A brass key, number 9, opened the cellar door without turning. The lock simply clicked when Mara held the key near it. Dr. Voss made a note and did not write down what the note meant.

At the foot of the stairs, seawater covered the floor by a finger's breadth. It moved toward a stone arch in the eastern wall. Beyond the arch was no room shown on the building plan, only a narrow passage lined with green glass. Each pane reflected the pair from a different year: Mara as a child, Voss with a beard gone white, both of them wearing coats they did not own.

The chart in the bottle warmed in Mara's hands. A new line appeared, ink spreading through the paper without a pen. It traced the passage and stopped at a circle beneath the harbor. From above came three measured strokes of the bell.

They did not count the fourth. The stone arch widened, and the tide began to climb the stairs. Mara folded the chart along its old creases. The drawn coastline vanished. The real one did not.

THE HORROR BENEATH THE WAVES!

A chart that redraws the coast. A bell with no tower. A door waiting below the tide.

When Mara Bell discovers a bottle no wave can wet, she finds a shoreline the world has forgotten. With Dr. Voss at her side, she descends into the customs house and hears the harbor answer a question no one asked.

A strange, salt-stained adventure of vanished minutes, impossible maps, and the dark geography beneath familiar streets.

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